Cloud of Witnesses, All Saints Day

By Roseann Lloyd

INTRODUCTION

According to the Family Violence Prevention Fund, On average, more than three women a day are murdered by their husbands or boyfriends in the United States and women experience two million injuries from intimate partner violence each year. Many of these women are mothers who often go to great and courageous lengths to protect their children from abusive partners. In fact, research has shown that the non-abusing parent is often the strongest protective factor in the lives of children who are exposed to domestic violence. However, growing up in a violent home may be a terrifying and traumatic experience that can affect every aspect of a child's life, growth and development. Roseann Lloyd has dedicated her poem Cloud of Witnesses, All Saints Day to the 18 Minnesota women who were murdered by their partners in 1989 and the 27 women who were murdered in 1990, and to their children. Cloud of Witnesses, All Saints Day by Roseann Lloyd.

1

Thanksgiving again, my daughter and I are coloring,
making shapes by tracing around our hands.

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She is making a turkey, her fingers are feathers now,
bright and brown, burnt sienna, maize, and umber.

I'm drawing rings on my fingers, emeralds and gold,
and when I start on the matching bracelet, I'm startled

to see my wrist so small on the cardboard,
looking like it belongs to a girl no older than 12.

How can it be mine, this woman no longer a girl?
I've put on weight, but I still have small bones.

2

His hands were even beefier than when we were married. Meathooks.
How did I ever manage to escape without any broken bones?

The question was: *Could we talk about our daughter's health*
with a third party present?

When she's at your house, I said,
is she getting beat up? Has she seen you

hitting anyone else?
You sound like a battered wife, he said.

I said, *That's because I was one.*
Fear rose in my throat, red blotches spread across my neck.

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His face was an odd combination of blankness and broken edges,
as though he'd been informed he had cancer of the brain.

He turned to face the therapist.
She never went in for x-rays.

The therapist asked me to relate one incident,
I picked the first time, the argument about keeping the dog.

Don't you see, he said, *I can't*
apologize - I don't remember. I have no emotional content

for what she's saying
He seemed to have no memory of

the other therapists we went to, each one saying
Hitting a woman is never acceptable.

It's possible it's true, he said.
I was always on edge in those days

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3

He was always careful not to break my glasses.
Careful to hit me on the back of the head, to pound the fleshy

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stomach, the uterus, the fat of my back.
Careful not to hit our daughter when she was snuggling on my lap.

Overweight means I don't feel vulnerable.
My wrists give me away.

The first time he hit me: Thanksgiving, 1971.
The term *battered wives* first used in research: 1974.

He used to be so careful, in surgery, tying tiny sutures.
An expert, he knew how to leave no marks that show.

The drawing of my hand looks like it belongs to a 12-year-old,
playing dress-up. Rings on her fingers, bells on her toes.

It was a shock to feel the floorboards, wind knocked out of me.
Like a child, I thought, how can someone who loves me do this?

In *The Times Book Review,* Jean Stafford, in braids, frowns
like a troubled girl, her husband, a batterer, stern beside her.

When I left him, I moved in with another man for protection.
It was the only way I knew to handle my fear.

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Now I'm ready at any moment to dial 911.
I wouldn't hesitate to take a knife to him without warning.

I've gained weight, but my bones are still small.
There's no fear in my body, I say, but the weight stays put.

I've never told anyone before-I can't
remember how he looks naked.
Our daughter didn't make plaster handprints in kindergarten.
I can see her hands, strong and sturdy even then.

The phrase *rule of thumb* comes from old English law -- wife-beating allowed if the stick's no bigger than his thumb.

When I told the story of how he beat me up, why, and how,
his face cracked like neglected plaster in an empty house.

I could never believe it was happening.
It was always a shock to be slammed sideways against a door.

He was careful not to break my glasses.
Bruises-raw umber-don't show on the back of the head.

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They told me it was good that I'd left when she was three.
But the body never forgets, the body of the marriage.

A boy in the hospital named our daughter Lady of the Woods.
She fell in love with crafts, working with her hands.

She made collages out of leaves, burned flowers into leather.
I dreamed of blue and green hands floating along a red wall.

Sometimes life hangs on by a fragile thread.
When she got out of the hospital her face was the color of milk.

It's the forever of it that I can't get used to, Tess cried,
placing her black moon bracelet on our daughter's wrist.

For years I hated my Bride Doll. I was ashamed.
Now she sits in honor, in her Chinese gold Lounging Pajamas.

Another woman said to me only this week:
I dread Thanksgiving coming I was in such danger in my marriage.

50% of murdered American women are killed by their own husbands.

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How can their daughters continue on?

In 1971, I was too scared to leave, knowing
most women are not killed until they're on the run.

In 1976, they wouldn't give me a restraining order:
doctors don't jeopardize their careers, they said.

As I packed, he said, *you're lucky to be getting out alive.*
After that, whenever I left the house, I checked for
cars, guns.

In 1981, my retinas detached themselves. The eye
doctors
wanted to know how many times I'd been hit in the head.

Overweight means I don't feel vulnerable.
But my wrists give me away.

In 1988, a bill was proposed to the Minnesota
Legislature:
if a man shoots his wife in Deer Season, it's a
misdemeanor.

The body never forgets.
Fear travels with me, at daycare, in the parking ramps.

Yesterday a grandmother's bones were found in the
river willows.
She was last seen at the Rosedale Mall, four months ago.

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In the next town, a doctor shot his wife in the head.
She was holding her children by the hand, walking out
the door.

Danger is everywhere but we know that Rosedale is not
where the worst danger lies.

It is difficult to determine the cause of death
when only the bones are found.

Our daughter wears bells, ankle bracelets, silver rings.
Her room, red and pink, with crystals and plants, her new
life.

Her father can wander in his memory loss
as I do in mine. I know why I've forgotten his naked
body.

Doctor, lawyer, white-collar thief ...
Why are educated men excused when they're
offenders?

Life hangs by a fragile thread.

At any moment it can snap, like the wishbone on
Thanksgiving.

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When she got out of the hospital, we went to the Garden

of Eden.

She bought perfume made of cucumbers and honeydew.

She is bringing herself back to life.

All the whys dissolve into mystery.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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